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Occupational Injuries, Insurance Gaps, and Prevention Strategies for Massage Therapists in the United States



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Introduction: Who Are Massage Therapists?

In the United States, massage therapy has become a widely popular therapeutic option. Frequently used for general wellness, disease prevention, or to address specific musculoskeletal health issues. Due to the public's enthusiasm for massage therapy, the industry has increasingly caught the attention of job seekers. According to surveys, the total number of massage therapists in the U.S. stood at approximately **134,150 workers** in 2023.[2] 78.2% were women, and 21.8% were men. In terms of racial and ethnic composition, 65.3% was white, 11.1% was Asian, and 10.3% was identify as two or more races. The age of them is primarily in between 30 and 44 years old, representing 40.6% of the total workforce.[2]



Massage therapists enhance people's well-being by employing professional manual techniques to manipulate soft tissues and muscles, thereby helping clients alleviate pain, reduce stress, or facilitate the accelerated recovery of injured tissues. This profession sits at the intersection of the healthcare and personal services sectors, which presents both opportunities and inherent industry vulnerabilities. On one hand, massage therapy is increasingly being recognized as a legitimate and indispensable component of the healthcare system. According to the Bureau of Labor Statistics, employment in the massage industry is **expected to grow by 15%** from 2024 to 2034, compared to the 3% average for all occupations,[1] this is a significant high rate of growth. Reports from the American Massage Therapy Association (AMTA) indicates that 91% of consumers believe that massage therapy is highly beneficial for improving the overall health and wellness to the society.[17] On the other hand, while the demand of the market continues to rise, the corresponding protections and benefit for the workers who deliver these services have not kept the same pace with this growth.

Unlike other industries, the massage industry is characterized by high rate of self-employment. According to the 2024 Massage Profession Research published by the AMTA, 73% of massage therapists are sole (or self-employed) practitioners,[3] another survey conducted by NCBTMB also places this figure at nearly 70%.[4] While self-employment offers flexibility and autonomy, it also means that the vast majority of massage therapists do not enjoy **the employer-provided benefit such as health insurance, worker's compensation and paid sick leave, or retirement benefits like other formally employed staff.** These self-employed massage therapists are operating without a safety net.

In most of the states in America, to practice legally, massage therapists must complete **minimum of 500 to 1,000 hours education** at a board-approved school, they have to pass the Massage and Bodywork Licensing Examination (MBLEx), and fulfill the continuing education requirements for license renewal.[5][16] Based on the 2025 Annual Report post by FSMTB, **17,160 candidates took the MBLEx exam during 2024–2025**, with a **first-time pass rate of 70.4%**.[5] Which shows that these certification requirements are not easy to meet. These exams represent significant investments of time and money the candidates need to put on. However, as this paper aims to demonstrate, this licensing system, designed to certify the professional competence of massage therapists, actually offers virtually no protection against the health risks, financial insecurities, or career challenges that these practitioners face once they are begging practicing.

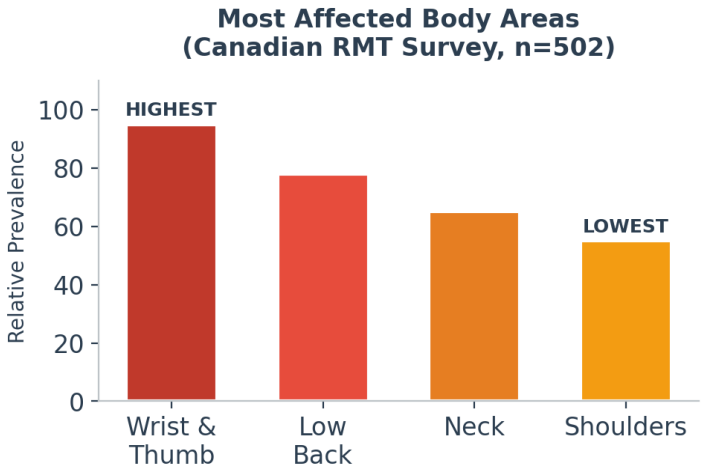
Occupational Health Risks for Massage Therapists

Massage therapy is a profession that requires a significant high level of **physical exertion.** This distinguishes it from most other healthcare professions. During each session – typically 60 to 90 minutes or longer – massage therapists must continuously use hard pressure to their hands, fingers, thumbs, forearms and elbows. And they won't just have one session per day, usually they need to complete multiple sessions per day. Unlike a doctor or nurse who typically shift between physical tasks and cognitive work, a massage therapist's work consists almost entirely of physical and repetitive tasks. The BLS explicitly notes that due to the extreme demands this workplace on physical strength and endurance, many therapists are unable to sustain 8-hour days and 5 days per week.[1] Although many massage therapists are paid based on the number of sessions they have in a day, this is not a profession where one can simply earn a higher income by extending the working hours. In contrast, excessive physical exertion directly accelerates the deterioration and burnout, ultimately leading to a short career life, or financial expenditure on personal physical recovery.

Musculoskeletal Injuries

Massage therapists are facing a high risk to get work-related musculoskeletal disorders (WMSDs). The most common sites of injury include the fingers, thumbs, wrists, shoulders, neck, and lower back.[8] These injures are a predictable consequence of the way the profession is structured. For example, when performing deep tissue massage, therapists need to apply sustained pressure using their thumbs and fingers. This places significant strain on the small joints, which can easily lead to repetitive strain injuries.

A survey of 502 registered massage therapists in Canada revealed that many experience muscle and joint pain—most commonly in the wrists and thumbs, followed by the lower back, neck, and shoulders,[9] most of respondents reported they are all learned proper posture and self-care techniques during their training, shows that such pain cannot be entirely avoided through individual adjustments alone, since it is the nature structure of this profession.



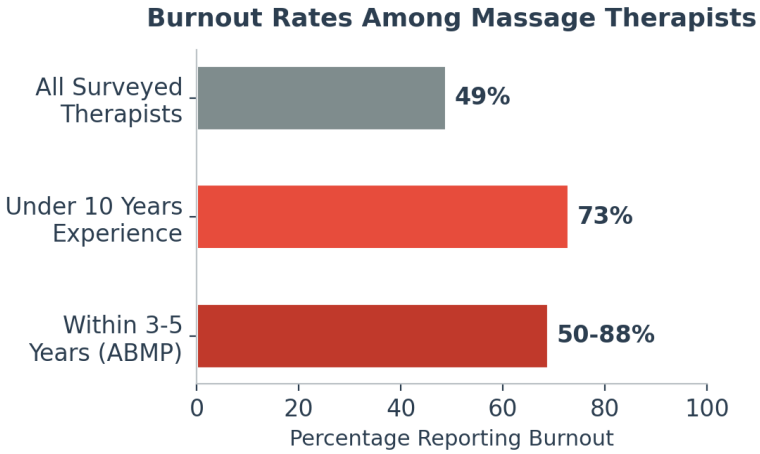
The most common injuries massage therapists face are:

- **Carpal Tunnel Syndrome** – median nerve compression in the wrist caused by repetitive hand and finger movements. It is the most common nerve compression disorder affecting the upper extremities. Since healing process for nerve tissue is extremely slow, recovery from carpal tunnel syndrome typically takes several months and may even require surgery, meaning that during this period, the therapists will be unable to work or earn money from their job.[11][13]
- **Medial Epicondylitis (Golfer's Elbow)** – caused by chronic overuse of wrist and finger flexor muscles, particularly during deep tissue techniques. When the tendon begins to degenerate, the condition becomes debilitating.[11]
- **Thoracic Outlet Syndrome** – nerve impingement resulting from sustained awkward postures maintained during sessions.[13]
- **Neck and Low Back Strain** – caused by prolonged forward flexion, bending, and reaching. Therapists spend a significant time during each treatment sessions in a forward-leaning position, which places substantial strain on the cervical spine and lumbar region.[11]
- **Tendinosis** – Due to prolonged, repetitive exertion, the tendons in the wrist and forearm will gradually become damaged and degenerate.[13]

For massage therapists who have been working full-time for many years, injury is often a foreseeable outcome. The real question is not whether they will get injured, but rather —should an injury occur—whether they have sufficient insurance and financial support to help them weather that period.

Burnout and Career Attrition

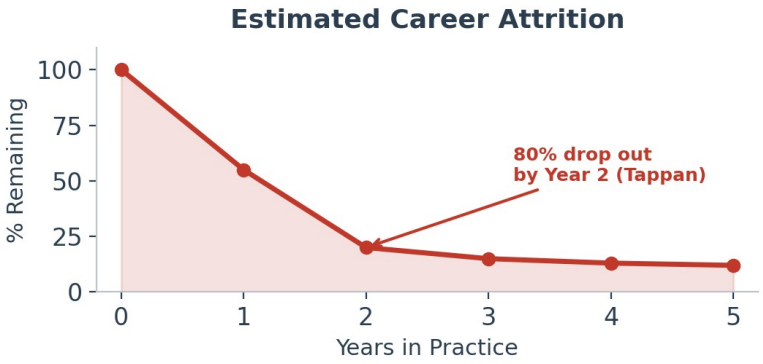
High-intensity physical labor, coupled with mental and emotional exhaustion, leads to a high rate of job burnout. According to a report by ABMP, **in the massage therapy industry, many practitioners experience burnout within the first 3 to 5 years after graduation, with rates ranging approximately from 50% to 88%.**[6] Tappan's research corroborates this finding, she notes that **80% of people who enter this field will choose to drop out within 2 years**, the primary reasons they mentioned were, their hands being "overburdened" and physical exhaustion.[7]



A survey conducted by HomeCEU found that **49% of massage therapists report having experienced professional burnout**. Among those who have worked 10 years of less, this figure is even higher, reaching 73%[10] This suggests that burnout is not solely a consequence of long working hours.[10] In other words, burnout among massage therapists is likely not merely a matter of being "too tired," but is instead linked to a host of other factors—such as the disparity between high physical exertion and modest income, limited opportunities for professional advancement, the frequent isolation inherent in the work, the emotional strain of providing long-term client care, and the anxiety stemming from a lack of financial security.

> *"Companies often take advantage of new graduates, offering them low pay and overwhelming them with full schedules." – Massage therapist respondent, HomeCEU 2024 survey*

Massage therapy **programs enroll over 50,000 new students annually, but 45,000 therapists leave the field each year**.[6] This shows that this industry were having completely turns over its entire workforce every few years. The average career life of a massage therapist is only three to five years which make a huge contrast to the hundreds of hours of training, licensing exams, and continuing education costs required before entering the field.



Continuing study and Injury-Forced Work Reduction

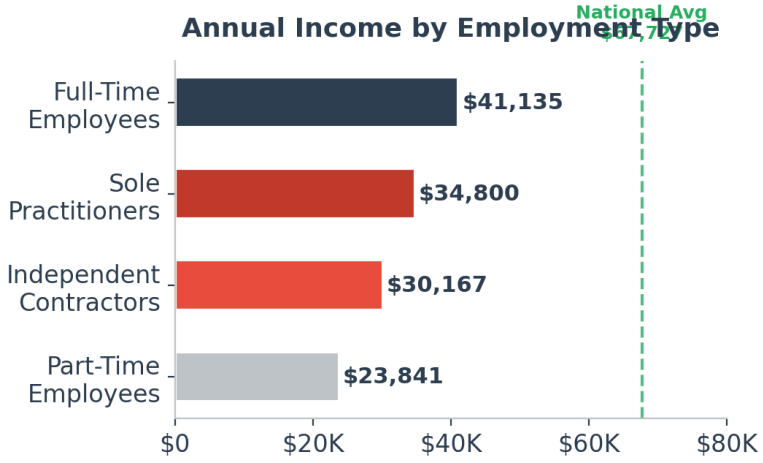
Therapists who are unwilling or unable to pay for continuing education always face a higher risk of getting work-related injuries.[8] This suggests that the financial burden associated with maintaining professional licensure may exacerbate occupational risks. When therapists reject doing continuing education courses due to the high fees, they become more vulnerable to injury. Especially when the continuing education can expose therapists to new findings and more effective techniques for injury prevention, body mechanics, and ergonomic practice that may not have been included in earlier training.

Barriers to Care

Although massage therapists are licensed practitioners whose therapeutic services are recognized by physicians and insurance companies, they still face numerous difficulties when seeking medical care and obtaining health coverage for themselves.

Insurance Gaps: The Independent Contractor Problem

As previously mentioned, 70% to 73% of massage therapists work as sole practitioners or independent contractors,[3][4] The majority of people are excluded from the employer-provided benefits system because they are counted as self-employment. These self-employed massage therapists must purchase their own health insurance—typically through the ACA marketplace. Under the U.S. tax laws, self-employer are required to set aside approximately 25% of their income to cover quarterly self-employment taxes.[15] After deducting various operating costs, the actual pay for many massage therapists is significantly lower than their apparent hourly rate.



The Annual Income data shows how serious this issue. According to the AMTA's 2024 report, individual practitioners earn an average annual gross income of just $34,800, while those working as independent contractors earn an average of $30,167 per year.[3] Data USA reports that in 2023, the average annual wage for massage therapists was $32,762 which is much lower than the national average wage of $67,727.[2] At this income level, purchasing individual health insurance through the ACA marketplace would consume a significant amount of their after-tax disposable income.

Misclassification and Workers' Compensation

Within the massage therapy industry, it is common to misclassify massage therapists as sole practitioners. Many massage therapists working in spas, chain establishments, and clinics are not counted as employees, however, they are performing the duties of employees. For examples, they are required to follow the work schedules designed by their employers, use equipment provided by their employers, and follow service rule of their employers. According to the standards established by the IRS and the Department of Labor, such individuals should typically be classified as formal employees. The AMTA also acknowledges that, in many instances, this classification is indeed incorrect.[14]

Misclassification brings many consequences, and ultimately fall upon the shoulders of the employees themselves. By classifying workers as independent contractors rather than full-time employees, companies can save up to 30% of labor cost, such as payroll taxes, unemployment insurance, and workers' compensation coverage.[15] However, this cost-saving comes at the direct expense of the massage therapists' best interests. Lacking workers' compensation coverage, should they develop any occupational injuries, there is **no mechanism in place to cover medical bills, surgical costs, or lost wages during their recovery period**. Eventually, they will leave with no choice but to pay out of their own pockets, forgo necessary treatment, or exit the profession entirely.

Professional Stigma

The massage industry also faces societal misconceptions regarding the profession. A survey conducts by HomeCEU revealed that some massage therapist experienced being mistaken as sex workers and encountering clients with inappropriate behavior.[10] This stigma not only subjects massage therapists to psychological stress and baseless accusations, but also compromises their safety.

Proposed Solutions: Workplace and Medical Interventions

Occupational injuries are a main reason why many people leave this profession. Therefore, reducing the risk of injury and detecting issues early on are the most direct ways to help massage therapists work longer and extend their careers.

Ergonomic Standards and Self-Care Protocols

One-off training sessions alone cannot truly resolve the issue. Massage therapists engage in repetitive use of their hands, fingers, wrists, and shoulders on a daily basis; unless work schedules and industry regulations undergo fundamental changes, no amount of personal self-monitoring will be sufficient to protect their bodies over the long term. The truly effective approach is to embed ergonomic requirements directly into workplace protocols and industry standards, transforming them into mandatory compliance measures rather than leaving them solely to the discretion of the therapists. For examples[11][12]:

- Therapists should have at least 10 to15-minute break after completing a session.
- Daily work schedule should be limited to prevent overload.
- Clinics or spas should proactively assess whether the height of massage tables, therapists' postures, and work schedules are appropriate.

These standards should be mandatory prerequisite for clinic, spa or beauty salon to obtain a business license.

Continuing Education Accessibility

States could offer **free or subsidized continuing education courses** focused on teaching massage therapists how to prevent injuries and master new body mechanics techniques. It could also be stipulated that if employers wish to hire massage therapists, they must reimburse at least a portion of their continuing education expenses. The FSMTB already operates the REACH platform which offers CE online learning platform, [5] which could serve as infrastructure for delivering subsidized injury-prevention content at scale.

Occupational Health Screening

In regions with a high concentration of massage therapists, doctors and nurses should receive training on how to recognize and address common work-related injuries among massage therapists. This would help health providers become more familiar with the occupational injuries massage therapists often face and offer more informed and effective treatment. Community health centers and occupational

health clinics could offer annual **specialized screenings** tailored to practitioners of manual therapies.[11][13]

Proposed Solutions: Public Health and Policy

While workplace interventions can mitigate individual risks, policy reform is also indispensable for achieving systemic change.

Employment Classification Reform

One of the most effective policies is to make the standard more strict when determining whether a massage therapist is an "independent practitioner" or an "employee." California's AB5 legislation serves as a great example. This law clarifies that, unless a company can prove that an individual simultaneously meets three specific conditions, that individual must be classified as an employee: 1. They perform their work free from the company's control; 2. The work they perform falls outside the company's primary line of business; 3. They are engaged in an independently established trade or business of their own. This classification change would allow many misclassified employees to gain protections they do not currently have. Such as health insurance, workers' compensation, unemployment insurance, and workplace safety safeguards provided by OSHA.[14]

Portable Benefits Models

For massage therapists who truly operate independently, the solution lies in **establishing a more flexible, portable benefits system (**one in which benefits remain tied to the individual worker, regardless of how their employment situation changes). For instance, the industry could collectively offer cheaper and suitable optional health insurance plans, or the government could establish a benefits fund supported by collecting a small fee on each service rendered. Additionally, ACA subsidies could be expanded to make it easier for self-employed therapists with fluctuating incomes to access assistance. In fact, the AMTA and the ABMP already include liability insurance as part of their membership services. This demonstrates that providing industry-wide benefits is indeed a feasible undertaking.

Disability Insurance Awareness

Massage therapists depend **entirely on their physical capabilities to generate income**, disability insurance is arguably more important for this profession than for most others profession. A single injury can completely strip a therapist of their entire earning capacity. Regrettably, disability insurance is not widely considered within this profession. This may be due to a lack of understanding among most therapists, an inability to afford the premiums, or a failure to recognize the severity of the risks they face.[13] Disability insurance education should be incorporated into professional licensing and training programs. Various professional massage associations should also actively advocate for preferential group disability insurance rates for their members.

Proposed Solutions: Education and Advocacy ACTIVITIES

Beyond clinical and policy interventions, education and public awareness campaigns can also improve public understanding of the massage therapy profession and help create support for better working conditions and compensation for practitioners.

Consumer-Facing Awareness Campaigns

According to AMTA's report, 91% of consumer agree that massage therapy is beneficial to health,[17] but few people consider the occupational risks and injuries faced by massage therapists. To increase public understanding of the profession through awareness campaigns would be an effective strategy. Modeled on the fair-trade movement in coffee,[19] such campaigns could help consumers better understand the long-term physical strain of massage work, the importance of tipping, and value of supporting business that provide therapist with formal employment status, comprehensive benefits, and reasonable scheduling. Once consumer become more informed, they may be better able to put pressure on the market and help encourage the entire industry to fairer and more sustainable practices.

Industry Association Advocacy

American Massage Therapy Association (AMTA) and Associated Bodywork & Massage Professionals (ABMP), as the two major organizations in the massage industry have strong data resources and large membership bases. They should make greater use of their resources and influence to support concrete legislation, including helping misclassified workers gain access to the benefits, promoting the unified workplace safety standards, and advocating for tax-related support policies. They could even create a "Massage Therapist Day," produce a show or conduct an event like *Jeopardy* about massage therapy that is open only to massage therapists. This could help strengthen therapists' sense of professional identity while also drawing more public attention to the industry. Although both organizations are actively working to advance the profession, they still need to devote more attention and effort to protecting the actual rights and interests of massage therapists.

Conclusion

In conclusion, over 134,000 massage therapists work in the United States. They are trained, they complete hundreds of hours of education, pass licensing exams, and invest a significant time and money to become a professional massage therapist and to provide better care for people. However, the industry fails to provide them with the protection and support their work requires – majority of them do not have health insurance, workers' compensation, and occupational safety protection.

Many therapists leave the field within just a few years, not because they are unqualified, but because the job places heavy physical demands on the body without enough structural support.

This is not only a fairness issue for workers, but also a long-term problem for the sustainability of the profession. To address this gap, the industry must move beyond professional licensing alone and invest in stronger labor protections, better benefits, safer working conditions, and greater public awareness of the value and cost of massage work.

There are over 134,000 licensed massage therapists in the United States. And they deserve more than a license. They deserve protection.

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